THE BULLOCK PRESIDENCY

BOOK ONE: BEFORE

Chapter 9 — "One Week"

Monday, August 19, 2024 – Wednesday, October 30, 2024

COLD OPEN — "CULTURE'S BIGGEST NIGHT"

INT. UNITED CENTER — CHICAGO — CONVENTION FLOOR — NIGHT

SUPER: MONDAY, AUGUST 19, 2024 — 8:00 PM CDT

SUPER: DEMOCRATIC NATIONAL CONVENTION — NIGHT ONE

The arena where Michael Jordan won three championships, transformed. No traditional speaker's podium with a wall of state signs behind it. Instead: a massive, multi-level stage built like an awards show. LED walls three stories tall. A twenty-four-piece live band in tuxedos on a riser to stage left. A host's mark at center stage with a single spotlight on it.

The delegates are on the floor with their state signs, as always, but tonight they're surrounded by things no convention has seen before: a red carpet running from the arena entrance to the floor, step-and-repeat walls, photographers shouting names.

In a production truck outside, behind forty monitors: ROBERT BULLOCK (55), volunteer creative director, unpaid, headset on, reading glasses on his forehead, calling cameras like he's directing the Oscars.

ROBERT
(into headset)
Camera six, find Georgia. Camera nine, stay on the band. Lights to blue. Cue the hosts in five, four, three...

The house goes dark. A single trumpet. Then the full band hits a brassy, explosive fanfare, and the LED walls fill with the words:

"THE DEMOCRATIC NATIONAL CONVENTION — CULTURE'S BIGGEST NIGHT."

Into the spotlight walk the hosts for Night One, in coordinated navy: TAYIA BOYD (32) and TYLER CHAPMAN (32), the only openly Republican host in the history of a Democratic convention.

TAYIA
Good evening, Chicago! Good evening, America!

TYLER
I'm a Republican. I'd like to say that right up front, so nobody's confused. I'm here because a man made me chair of an organization with one member and it now has four hundred thousand.

The arena roars.

TAYIA
Welcome to the Democratic National Convention, y'all. Tonight we're doing it a little different.

TYLER
Senators, we see you. You'll get your time. It's just going to be between songs.

A wave of laughter through the arena. On the floor, in the Pennsylvania delegation, a sitting U.S. senator laughs, a little nervously.

MONTAGE — THE CONVENTION — AUGUST 19–22, 2024

— NIGHT ONE: President Joe Biden (81) walks onto the stage to a four-minute standing ovation, the band playing "Jackie Wilson Said." He gives a valedictory speech about fifty years in public life and closes by pointing to the young man waiting in the wings: "Kid, you've got this." Marc comes out, uninvited, and hugs him. The President pretends to be annoyed. He isn't.

— NIGHT ONE: An in-memoriam segment, done like an awards show, with soft music and faces on the screen: Corey Comperatore. The victims of Lahaina. The Key Bridge workers. Americans the country lost that year. The arena on its feet in total silence.

SUPER: TUESDAY, AUGUST 20, 2024 — NIGHT TWO — THE ROLL CALL

The ceremonial roll call, staged by Robert like a concert: a DJ playing each state's signature song as its delegation casts its votes. Alabama, the Commodores. Alaska. Arizona. Arkansas. California, "California Love," and the arena goes berserk. Colorado. Connecticut. Delaware, and the cameras find the President, laughing.

Then the DJ cuts the music. The arena goes quiet. A camera finds the Georgia delegation.

Standing at the microphone in the Georgia section: CORNELIUS SMILLEY (66), in his father's burgundy tie. Beside him, in a wheelchair, in a white church hat with a brim like a satellite dish, ODESSA SMILLEY (95). Behind them: Lorraine (62), Neil (40), and Simone (37), the only registered Republican on the Georgia floor, holding an "I'M JUST HERE FOR GRANDMA" sign.

In the family box above the stage, Esther (31) grabs Marc's arm. Marc (32) sits forward. He hasn't been told who's casting Georgia's votes. Nobody has.

Cornelius looks up at the box. Then down at the paper in his hand. Then he folds the paper and puts it in his pocket.

CORNELIUS
(into the microphone)
Madam Secretary. Georgia. The state where my father marched. Where my mother has sat in the third pew of the same church since 1952. Where my brother is buried. The state that fifty-two years ago elected the first Black congressman from the Deep South since Reconstruction, and the state that sent this country Martin Luther King Jr. and Jimmy Carter.

(beat)
I'd like to yield to the oldest delegate on this floor. My mother. Odessa Grant Smilley. Ninety-five years old.

The arena roars as the camera finds Odessa. Cornelius lowers the microphone to her. She takes it in both hands like a hymnal.

ODESSA
Madam Secretary. Georgia casts one hundred and eight votes for the next President of the United States.

(beat)
My grandson-in-law.

The United Center EXPLODES. The DJ drops "Georgia on My Mind," the Ray Charles version, and twenty-three thousand people sing along. In the family box, Marc is on his feet, both hands on top of his head, crying openly. Esther is sobbing into his shoulder. Emma and Victoria (12) are screaming. Lyric (10) is standing on her chair.

On the Georgia floor, Odessa hands the microphone back to her son. Cornelius takes it. Leans in one more time.

CORNELIUS
And from her son...

(a long beat; twenty-three thousand people wait)
...so does Cornelius Smilley.

If the roar before was an explosion, this one is a detonation. Neil Smilley throws his arms around his father. Cornelius, stiff as a church pew, lets him.

Twitter · #GeorgiaRollCall

Trending #1 Worldwide · 3.9M Tweets

> **Twitter · @TheBullpenDaily**
>
> ODESSA SMILLEY, 95, CAST GEORGIA'S VOTES FOR HER "GRANDSON-IN-LAW." THEN CORNELIUS SAID "SO DOES CORNELIUS SMILLEY." THE MAN WHO RAN BIDEN'S FIREWALL. I CANNOT BREATHE.
>
> **501K Retweets · 3.4M Likes**

— NIGHT THREE, WEDNESDAY: Amond Baker accepts the vice-presidential nomination. Gloria Baker introduces him with a story about the trampoline. The speech is the best of the convention: "The job isn't to be important. The job is to be useful." Lyric, on stage at the end, says into the mic, "Same thing," and nobody knows exactly what she means, and everybody loves it.

SUPER: THURSDAY, AUGUST 22, 2024 — NIGHT FOUR

— The final night. Before the nominee, a surprise. The lights drop. A single spotlight on an empty stage. A voice, one note, from the darkness, a note every person in the arena knows.

TYRESE AVERY (33), unseen in public for seven months, walks into the light in a white suit, singing "Afterglow." The arena makes a sound like a jet engine. He sings it slower than he ever has, just piano and voice, and he doesn't say a word before or after. When the last note fades, he points up at the family box, at Marc, touches his heart, and walks off the stage. Back into the "sabbatical." Back into the dark.

> **Twitter · @tyreseslayss_**
>
> HE CAME BACK FOR ONE SONG AND LEFT WITHOUT SAYING A WORD. WHERE IS HE GOING. WHAT IS HE DOING. I'M CANADIAN AND I JUST REGISTERED AS A DEMOCRAT OUT OF SPITE.
>
> **211K Retweets · 1.6M Likes**

— In the upper deck, Section 324, Row 11, in a seat she paid $340 for on a resale site with her own credit card: Natasha Bullock (53). Beside her, Victor (78) and Joan (76) in seats they also bought themselves. The CEO of the most valuable company on Earth eating nachos out of a plastic tray. No one recognizes her for nine minutes. Then someone does, and the whole section stands and applauds her, and she waves them down, mortified.

— BACKSTAGE, 9:41 PM CDT. A narrow hallway. Marc, in a navy suit, ten minutes from the biggest speech of his life. Dante hands him an envelope. "FOR MARC — CHICAGO." Marc opens it. Cornelius's legal-pad page from August tenth. Six items. Marc reads it twice. Folds it. Puts it in his breast pocket. Over his heart.

— 10:02 PM CDT. The acceptance speech. Forty-four minutes. Twelve standing ovations. The line that ends up on every front page in

America the next morning: "My father-in-law taught me something two weeks ago. He said people forgive ambition, but they don't forgive arithmetic. So here's my arithmetic: one country, three hundred and thirty-five million people, zero people left behind. Let's fix it."

— 10:46 PM CDT. Balloons. A hundred thousand of them, navy and white. The band plays "Ain't No Mountain High Enough." The Bullocks and Bakers and Smilleys onstage together for the first time in history: Odessa in her wheelchair at the center, Cornelius standing behind her, his hand on her shoulder. Marc goes to him. Holds out his hand. Cornelius looks at it for a long second. Then he shakes it. And then, to the shock of everyone on that stage and twenty-three thousand people in the arena, he pulls his son-in-law into a stiff, brief, unmistakable hug.

THE NEW YORK TIMES — FRI, AUG 23

Bullock Accepts Nomination in a Convention Unlike Any Other: Part Awards Show, Part Revival, Part Family Reunion

VARIETY — AUG 23

DNC Final Night Draws 38 Million Viewers, a Record for a Convention; Robert Bullock's Production Hailed as 'the Oscars of Politics'

AP — FRI, AUG 23

Robert F. Kennedy Jr. suspends independent presidential bid, endorses Trump

ACT ONE — "SEPTEMBER, OCTOBER"

MONTAGE — AUGUST 23 TO OCTOBER 28, 2024 — HEADLINES, POSTS, AND MOMENTS

POLITICO — AUG 30

Trump Agrees to One Debate With Bullock, Citing Ratification Progress; ABC Ruled Out Over Donohue Conflict; NBC to Host in Philadelphia Sept. 10

SUPER: TUESDAY, SEPTEMBER 10, 2024 — 9:00 PM EDT — NATIONAL CONSTITUTION CENTER, PHILADELPHIA

— The only presidential debate of the general election. NBC News. Two podiums. DONALD TRUMP (78), confident, combative, at full strength. MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK (32), calm, a bluebird pin on his lapel.

Trump lands real punches: on the border ("He wants to erase it"), on the North American Union ("a globalist fantasy"), on Marc's age, on the Donohue conflict. For the first twenty minutes, Trump is winning. Pundits on social media say so in real time.

Then the moderator asks Trump about his conviction. Trump attacks the judge, the prosecutors, the jury. When it's Marc's turn to respond, he doesn't attack.

MARC (ON SCREEN)
I'm not going to talk about his case. A jury did that. I want to talk about the fact that two months ago somebody tried to kill this man, and he's standing here anyway, on a debate stage, arguing with a thirty-two-year-old. Whatever else you think of him, that takes guts. I respect it.

(beat)
Now let me tell you why he's wrong about everything else.

The audience, instructed to stay silent, laughs out loud. Even Trump almost smiles.

The rest of the debate is a brawl, an even one for long stretches. But the instant polls afterward: CNN, Bullock 58, Trump 39. YouGov, Bullock 54, Trump 37. Fox's own focus group in Pennsylvania splits, with the majority saying Bullock "seemed more presidential," which the Fox host repeats twice, as if he can't believe it.

AP — SUN, SEPT 15

Secret Service fires on armed man near Trump at his Florida golf club; Trump unharmed. Bullock calls Trump for the second time in two months.

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL — WED, SEPT 18

Fed Cuts Rates by Half Point, First Cut Since 2020

SUPER: FRIDAY, SEPTEMBER 27 – SUNDAY, SEPTEMBER 29, 2024 — HURRICANE HELENE

— Western North Carolina. Swannanoa. Chimney Rock. Asheville. Rivers that have never flooded in recorded history have swallowed entire towns. Roads gone. Bridges gone. Cell service gone.

— SUNDAY, SEPTEMBER 29, 3:12 PM EDT. A muddy church parking lot in Swannanoa, North Carolina, turned into a supply depot. Pallets of water. Generators. Chainsaws. A line of flatbed trucks with "BULLOCK FOUNDATION" stenciled on the side. No campaign signs. No press allowed within a mile; Marc insisted.

Working the line in rubber boots and a filthy t-shirt: Marc. Beside him, handing out cases of water, sleeves rolled up, in a seventy-dollar pair of rubber boots he bought at a Tractor Supply on the way in: CORNELIUS SMILLEY (66).

They don't talk much. They just work. An ELDERLY WHITE WOMAN (80s), in a raincoat over a nightgown, comes through the line. She takes a case of water from Cornelius. Squints at him. Then at Marc.

ELDERLY WOMAN
You're that boy from the television.

MARC
Yes, ma'am.

ELDERLY WOMAN
I'm voting for the other fella.

MARC
That's okay, ma'am. Take two cases.

She looks at him. Takes two cases. Then she looks at Cornelius.

ELDERLY WOMAN
Who are you?

CORNELIUS
I'm his father-in-law, ma'am.

ELDERLY WOMAN
You voting for him?

A long beat. Marc glances over. Cornelius loads another case into her cart.

CORNELIUS
Yes, ma'am. I am.

She nods. Pushes her cart away. Marc stares at his father-in-law. Cornelius doesn't look at him.

CORNELIUS
Don't make it a whole thing.

MARC
...Have you been talking to Roy Chapman?

CORNELIUS
He has my number. He calls me on Thursdays. I don't know how it started.

SUPER: TUESDAY, OCTOBER 1, 2024 — 9:00 PM EDT — THE VICE PRESIDENTIAL DEBATE — CBS NEWS — NEW YORK CITY

— Senator JD VANCE (40) vs. AMOND BAKER (32). Vance is sharp, polished, and relentless: on immigration, on the age amendment ("If they can't wait two years, why should we trust them with four?"), on the Sovereign Fund ("a fairy tale with a logo"). By most accounts he has the stronger first half. Amond is nervous for the first fifteen minutes, then finds his footing on healthcare and on his mother's thirty-one years of teaching. The instant poll is close: Vance 49, Baker 47. The verdict: a draw, maybe a narrow Vance win. Amond tells reporters afterward, "He's good. He's really good. I'm going to call my mama now and she's going to tell me everything I did wrong."

CBS NEWS — WED, OCT 2

VP Debate Instant Poll: Vance 49%, Baker 47%; Voters Call It a Near-Draw

— THURSDAY, OCTOBER 3. The Smilley parlor, Atlanta. Odessa's ninety-sixth birthday. Marc flies in for three hours between rallies in Charlotte and Savannah. He brings a cake shaped like a church hat. Odessa cries. Cornelius cuts the cake.

AP — WED, OCT 9

Hurricane Milton Makes Landfall Near Siesta Key, Florida, as Category 3

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL — THU, OCT 10

Inflation Falls to 2.4%, Lowest Since February 2021

SUPER: MONDAY, OCTOBER 14, 2024 — A NEW TELEVISION AD

— A thirty-second spot airing in Texas, Arizona, Georgia, Pennsylvania, Michigan, Wisconsin, and North Carolina. A brick ranch house in Houston. A recliner. A man in a Navy veteran's cap, reading glasses on a lanyard, speaking directly to camera.

ROY CHAPMAN (ON SCREEN)
My name is Roy Chapman. I'm sixty-seven years old. I'm a Navy veteran. I was a refinery foreman for thirty-one years. I've voted Republican in every election since 1976.

(beat)
This year, I'm voting for Marc-Anthony Bullock.

(beat)
I don't agree with him on everything. I told him so. To his face. He listened. Then he sent forty-two thousand dollars to my neighborhood food bank because a bunch of old Republicans gave him twenty bucks.

(beat)
That's not politics. That's manners.

(beat, looking right into the camera)
And don't make it a whole thing.

Card: "BULLOCK ✦ BAKER. LET'S FIX IT." A small line at the bottom: "Paid for by Bullock for America."

AD AGE — OCT 16

'Don't Make It a Whole Thing': Roy Chapman Ad Becomes Most-Viewed Political Spot of the Cycle, 140 Million Views in 48 Hours

Twitter · @RoyChapmanHouston

They told me it would air in seven states. Now my grandson says I'm "a meme." I don't know what that means. I know my wife's cousin in Lubbock called me for the first time since 1993.

801K Retweets · 5.9M Likes

SUPER: SUNDAY, OCTOBER 27, 2024 — MADISON SQUARE GARDEN, NEW YORK

— A Trump rally at Madison Square Garden. Twenty thousand people. Among the warm-up speakers, a comedian calls Puerto Rico "a floating island of garbage." The line spreads across the internet within minutes. Puerto Rican celebrities, politicians, and ordinary families respond with fury. The Trump campaign distances itself from the remark.

— Also among the warm-up speakers that afternoon, in a cowboy hat, telling the crowd that "Hollywood is trying to install a nepo baby," to a smattering of applause: Jaxon Wilde (33).

— MONDAY, OCTOBER 28, 10:00 AM AST. San Juan, Puerto Rico. The waterfront at La Perla. Marc, unannounced, steps off a boat at the dock. The same dock where, in October 2017, a flotilla of relief ships he sent arrived after Hurricane Maria, before the federal government waived the Jones Act. He stands in front of a crowd of a few hundred people who followed the rumor down to the water.

MARC (ON SCREEN)
Seven years ago, after Maria, I sent ships to this dock. Some people in Washington said it was illegal. I said, "Then arrest me after they've had water."

(beat)
Yesterday somebody stood on a stage in New York and called this island garbage. I came here to say what I said seven years ago. You're not garbage. You're Americans. Three million of you. And if I'm President, Puerto Rico will never again be treated like an afterthought.

The crowd at La Perla, many of them in tears, starts chanting in Spanish: "¡BET! ¡BET! ¡BET!"

EL NUEVO DÍA — MON, OCT 28

Bullock Llega a La Perla Sin Aviso: "Ustedes No Son Basura. Son Americanos."

— MONDAY, OCTOBER 28, 8:14 PM EDT. A CNN studio in Washington. Simone Smilley (37), Republican commentator, on a panel. The anchor asks the question every panelist gets a week before an election: "Who are you voting for?"

Simone takes a long breath. Looks into the camera.

SIMONE (ON SCREEN)
I've been a Republican since I was nineteen. I worked for Nikki Haley. I spoke at our convention in Milwaukee. I've never voted for a Democrat for anything. Not dogcatcher. Not school board.

(beat)
I'm voting for my brother-in-law.

(beat)
Not because I agree with him on the border. I don't. Not because I believe in a North American Union. I don't. Because I watched him fly to Puerto Rico this morning to tell three million Americans they're not garbage. And because I watched him and my father hand out water in the mud in North Carolina for two days without a single camera. I've known him since he was eleven. He's never once been cruel. Not once.

(beat)
My party used to stand for character. I'm going with character.

CNN — OCT 28

Prominent GOP Strategist Simone Smilley, Haley Adviser, Says She Will Vote for Bullock

Twitter · @SimoneSmilley

I said it. I meant it. My grandmother called me nine seconds after the segment ended and said, "Took you long enough."

301K Retweets · 2.4M Likes

ACT TWO — "ONE WEEK OUT"

INT. ABC NEWS — "WORLD NEWS TONIGHT" — NEW YORK — EVENING

SUPER: TUESDAY, OCTOBER 29, 2024 — 6:30 PM EDT / 3:30 PM PDT

SUPER: ONE WEEK UNTIL ELECTION DAY

David Muir (50) at the desk, leaning in. The graphic behind him: "ELECTION 2024 — 7 DAYS."

DAVID MUIR
Good evening, and thank you for being with us. We begin tonight one week out. Seven days until Election Day. And we're going to show you exactly where this race stands tonight, in the polls, in the early vote, in the battlegrounds, and in a fight over the Constitution that could decide who actually takes the oath of office in January.

CHYRON: ONE WEEK OUT: WHERE THE RACE STANDS

DAVID MUIR
More than fifty-three million Americans have already voted, early or by mail, a pace close to 2020's record. Tonight Marc-Anthony Bullock is in Philadelphia for what his campaign calls his "closing argument," on the steps of the Philadelphia Museum of Art. Donald Trump is holding rallies in Pennsylvania and Michigan. Both campaigns say the same thing: this race will be decided in seven states, and maybe two more.

Muir turns to a giant touchscreen. The ABC POLITICAL DIRECTOR stands beside it.

DAVID MUIR
Let's start with the national picture.

GRAPHIC — "NATIONAL POLLING AVERAGE (538): BULLOCK 51.2% · TRUMP 45.4%"

ABC POLITICAL DIRECTOR
Bullock leads by about six points nationally. That's down from his post-convention high of eleven, at the end of August. The race tightened in September and early October, mostly on immigration and the North American Union. Trump's ads on the border, "He Wants to Erase It," have been the most-aired spots of the campaign. But it's been stable at about six for two weeks. And the Madison Square Garden rally on Sunday does not appear to have helped Trump. Early polling suggests the Puerto Rico remark hurt him with Latino voters in Pennsylvania and Florida.

DAVID MUIR
And the electoral map?

A map of the United States. Solid states shaded. Seven states pulse gold.

ABC POLITICAL DIRECTOR
Here's our ABC News/538 forecast. Safe and likely states give Bullock two hundred and twenty-six electoral votes, Trump two hundred and nineteen. Two hundred and seventy wins. The seven battlegrounds: Pennsylvania, Michigan, Wisconsin, Georgia, North Carolina, Arizona, Nevada. Plus two states we're watching closely that nobody thought would be in play: Texas and Florida.

He taps each battleground, and a polling average appears on it.

ABC POLITICAL DIRECTOR
Michigan: Bullock plus five. Wisconsin: Bullock plus four. Pennsylvania, the biggest prize: Bullock plus three, inside the margin of error. Georgia: Bullock plus two. North Carolina: tied. After Helene, nobody knows what turnout looks like in the western mountains. Nevada: Bullock plus four. Arizona, the state the border ads were built for: Trump plus one.

DAVID MUIR
And Texas?

ABC POLITICAL DIRECTOR
Texas: Trump plus two. Two. In Texas. No Democrat has won it since Jimmy Carter in 1976. Roy Chapman's ad has run there more than any other ad in the state. Florida: Trump plus four, but tightening since Sunday.

DAVID MUIR
So what's the forecast?

GRAPHIC — "538 FORECAST: BULLOCK WINS 74 IN 100 SIMULATIONS · TRUMP 26 IN 100"

ABC POLITICAL DIRECTOR
Bullock wins about three out of four times in our simulations. Which means one in four times, Trump wins. That's not a lock, David. Trump was given roughly a three-in-ten chance in 2016.

DAVID MUIR
And we'll remind viewers that ABC News and 538 are owned by Donohue Entertainment, in which Mr. Bullock holds a stake through a blind trust.

INT. BULLOCK FOR AMERICA HQ — CENTURY CITY — WAR ROOM — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 3:34 PM PDT

The war room has expanded. It's taken over an entire floor. A wall of screens. A twenty-foot map of the battleground states with county-level data. Patti Grove (60) stands in front of it with a laser pointer, like a general.

Around her: Elxa (34; she turned thirty-four on August 29, during the post-convention bus tour, in Erie, Pennsylvania, at a Sheetz), Grace (30), Arianna (32; she turned thirty-two four days ago and spent it in the Kentucky State Capitol arguing with a legislative counsel), and a dozen senior staffers.

PATTI
Seventy-four in a hundred. I hate it.

GRACE
Seventy-four is good!

PATTI
Seventy-one was good. In 2016. For somebody else. You know what happened.

She points the laser at Pennsylvania.

PATTI
Here's the truth. We win Michigan, Wisconsin, and Pennsylvania, we win. Period. That's the blue wall. Two seventy on the nose with everything else we're favored in. Georgia's gravy. Nevada's gravy. North Carolina's a dream. Arizona's a fight. Texas...

She points the laser at Texas.

PATTI
Texas is Roy Chapman's fault. Two points. I've never been within two points in Texas in my life. Nobody has since 1976. If we win Texas, I'm moving to Houston and taking up line dancing.

ELXA
And if we lose Pennsylvania?

Patti doesn't answer right away.

PATTI
Then we need Georgia AND North Carolina AND Arizona. Or Texas. Without Pennsylvania, this gets very scary very fast.

She turns to Arianna.

PATTI
Counselor. Tell me about the thirty-eight.

Arianna stands. She looks exhausted. She has a tracker on her laptop: a map of all fifty states, filled in one color for "ratified," one for "pending," one for "not in session."

ARIANNA
Thirty-three states have ratified the 28th Amendment. We need thirty-eight. Five more.

PATTI
Where are they going to come from?

ARIANNA
There are nine states left where it's realistic. Most of their legislatures aren't in session until January. Governors in four of them have said they'd call special sessions after the election. Two have flatly refused until January. The rest are waiting to see who wins. I've been to Frankfort, Kentucky, three times this month. I've had lunch with the Speaker of the Missouri House twice. I know the name of the legislative counsel in Montana's dog.

ELXA
What's the dog's name?

ARIANNA
Gunner. He's a Labrador. He doesn't like me.

PATTI
And if we don't get five by January twentieth?

Arianna looks around the room. Everyone already knows. She says it anyway.

ARIANNA
If Marc and Amond win on November fifth, and five more states don't ratify by noon on January twentieth, neither of them can take the oath. Under the Twentieth Amendment and the Presidential Succession Act, the Speaker of the House becomes Acting President until somebody qualifies. Marc turns thirty-five in January 2027. Amond in February 2027. So the Speaker of the new House, elected January third, would be Acting President of the United States for two years.

Silence.

GRACE
...So the House races are presidential races.

ARIANNA
The House races have been presidential races since July first, Grace.

BACK TO: "WORLD NEWS TONIGHT"

SUPER: 6:41 PM EDT

DAVID MUIR
Which brings us to Congress. And this year, for a reason that has never existed before in American history, the race for the House of Representatives could decide who is President.

A graphic: "28TH AMENDMENT RATIFICATION: 33 OF 38 STATES."

ABC POLITICAL DIRECTOR
If the amendment isn't ratified by thirty-eight states by inauguration day, and Bullock and Baker win, neither can serve. The new Speaker of the House would act as President. Right now, Republicans control the House by a handful of seats, with Speaker Mike Johnson. Democrats need a net gain of four seats to take the majority.

DAVID MUIR
And where does that stand?

GRAPHIC — "GENERIC CONGRESSIONAL BALLOT: DEM 50% · GOP 45%" — "HOUSE FORECAST: DEMOCRATS FAVORED (68 in 100)"

ABC POLITICAL DIRECTOR
Democrats lead the generic ballot by five, and our forecast favors them to take the House. The Bullock campaign has made the House a centerpiece of its closing argument, essentially telling voters: if you want Bullock to be President, you also need a Democratic House, as insurance. Republicans have countered with a simpler message: a Republican House means a Republican Speaker, which means, possibly, a Republican President, no matter what happens at the top of the ticket.

DAVID MUIR
And the Senate?

A Senate map.

ABC POLITICAL DIRECTOR
Here, the map favors Republicans. Democrats are defending seats in states Trump won in 2020: Montana and Ohio, plus West Virginia, where Joe Manchin is retiring and the Republican governor, Jim Justice, is heavily favored. Montana: Senator Jon Tester is essentially tied with Republican Tim Sheehy. Ohio: Senator Sherrod Brown, up one. Pennsylvania: Senator Bob Casey, up two. And in Texas, Democrat Colin Allred is within a point of Ted Cruz, the closest Texas Senate race since 2018. If Democrats hold Montana and Ohio and flip Texas, they'd have fifty-one seats. Fifty-two if they also pull off an upset in Florida or Nebraska.

DAVID MUIR
A week out, and nothing is settled.

ABC POLITICAL DIRECTOR
Nothing at all.

INT. SMILLEY HOUSE — PARLOR — ATLANTA — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 6:46 PM EDT

Odessa (96), Lorraine (62), and Neil (40). On the sideboard, the remains of the church-hat birthday cake, now three weeks old, preserved under a glass dome because Odessa refuses to throw it away.

Cornelius (66) isn't in his chair. He's standing at the window with his phone to his ear, talking low.

CORNELIUS
(into phone)
— Reverend, I understand. I understand. Last time I called you, I told you love wasn't a qualification. I was wrong. Love is the only qualification. Sunday. I'll be in your pulpit if you'll have me. And I'll bring my mother.

He hangs up. Turns. Odessa is watching him.

ODESSA
That's the same pastor you called in February. Raleigh.

CORNELIUS
Same pastor.

ODESSA
What did he say?

CORNELIUS
He said, "Cornelius, I've been waiting eight months for you to call me back and say that."

Odessa laughs. Lorraine laughs. Neil stares at his father as though he's never seen him before.

NEIL
Daddy. Are you campaigning for Marc?

CORNELIUS
I'm visiting churches. With my mother. A man can visit churches.

NEIL
In North Carolina. A week before the election. Telling pastors love is the only qualification.

CORNELIUS
North Carolina is tied, Neil. After Helene, half of those mountain counties don't have polling places. The pastors in the east are the only ones who can get people to the polls. I built that firewall for Biden in February. I'm going to rebuild it for my son-in-law in November.

Neil opens his mouth. Closes it. Then he grins.

NEIL
You just called him your son-in-law. Out loud. In Big Mama's parlor.

CORNELIUS
He IS my son-in-law. What would you like me to call him?

ODESSA
You used to call him "that Donohue."

CORNELIUS
(a long pause)
...People change, Mother.

ODESSA
Not in my experience. But you're my first.

INT. TRUMP CAMPAIGN — WAR ROOM — WEST PALM BEACH, FLORIDA — SAME TIME

SUPER: 6:49 PM EDT

A fictionalized room: a bank of screens, a whiteboard covered in county numbers. At a laptop, sleeves rolled up, in a red tie: WES THORNTON (45), now a senior strategist on the Trump campaign's paid-media team. On the screen in front of him, the Roy Chapman ad.

A YOUNGER STRATEGIST (30s) drops a printout on his desk.

YOUNGER STRATEGIST
Texas internals. Two points. Our own internals. Two.

WES THORNTON
I've seen it.

YOUNGER STRATEGIST
That old man in the recliner is killing us in the suburbs. Collin County. Fort Bend. Williamson. We need something.

WES THORNTON
We have something. "He Wants to Erase It." Border ads, eighty-eight days straight. Arizona's moving. North Carolina's tied.

YOUNGER STRATEGIST
That's not enough to stop Pennsylvania. Do we still have the comedy clips? The super PAC stuff from last fall?

Wes looks at his laptop. A folder on the desktop: "BULLOCK — ROAST MATERIAL (SOURCE: CS)." He's run those ads before. They hurt Marc in South Carolina. They barely moved anything in the general.

WES THORNTON
We ran those. Nobody cares anymore. He apologized. Sort of. Then his father-in-law handed out water in North Carolina for two days and the clips stopped working.

YOUNGER STRATEGIST
His father-in-law? Isn't that the guy who gave us the —

WES THORNTON
(sharply)
Don't.

A beat.

WES THORNTON
That man blocked my number in April. Told me to lose it. I thought he'd come crawling back by Labor Day.

(beat)
He's in a church in Raleigh on Sunday, telling pastors love is the only qualification. I've been doing this twenty years. I've never seen anyone flip that hard.

He closes the laptop.

WES THORNTON
Run the border. Run it everywhere. And put more money in Arizona and North Carolina. If we lose Pennsylvania, we need both.

INT. CHAPMAN HOUSE — MEYERLAND, HOUSTON — SAME TIME

SUPER: 5:52 PM CDT

Roy (67), in the recliner, watching himself on TV in the ad break during "World News Tonight." "Don't make it a whole thing." He groans and puts a hand over his face.

His wife, MAE CHAPMAN (65), in the kitchen doorway, laughing.

MAE
That's the ninth time tonight, Roy.

ROY
I know, Mae.

MAE
Your sister in Corpus called. She said she's voting for him.

ROY
My sister in Corpus hasn't voted since Reagan.

MAE
She said, "If Roy can do it, I can do it."

Roy takes off his reading glasses. Looks at the TV. At the poll graphic: "TEXAS: TRUMP +2."

ROY
Two points.

MAE
Two points.

ROY
Mae, if Texas goes for a Democrat because of me, my daddy's going to rise out of the ground in Beaumont and slap me.

MAE
Your daddy voted for LBJ, Roy.

Roy turns slowly to look at his wife.

ROY
...He did?

MAE
1964. Your mama told me in 1981. Made me swear never to tell you. She said you'd "make it a whole thing."

ACT THREE — "THE CLOSING ARGUMENT"

EXT. PHILADELPHIA MUSEUM OF ART — THE EAST ENTRANCE STEPS — NIGHT

SUPER: TUESDAY, OCTOBER 29, 2024 — 7:38 PM EDT

The seventy-two steps made famous by a fictional boxer running up them in gray sweats. Tonight the steps are a stage. At the top, a podium with the city skyline behind it, the Benjamin Franklin Parkway stretching all the way to City Hall, and on that parkway, from the steps to Logan Circle and beyond: a crowd the Philadelphia Police estimate at one hundred and ten thousand people.

Navy and white everywhere. "BET." hats. "LET'S FIX IT" signs. Signs in Spanish. Signs in Korean. A banner from a Puerto Rican social club in North Philly: "NO SOMOS BASURA — BULLOCK." And dozens of hand-drawn signs that just say "DON'T MAKE IT A WHOLE THING."

On the steps, waiting: Esther (32), who turned thirty-two on September twentieth, at a campaign stop in Kenosha, Wisconsin, eating frozen custard. Emma and Victoria (12), pulled out of school for two days, with a teacher's note signed "Mrs. Edna" from the Bel Air vote center as a joke. Lyric (10). Amond (32) and Harmony (32). And off to the side, in a wheelchair, wrapped in a blanket against the October chill: Odessa Smilley (96), who insisted on coming. Behind her, a hand on her shoulder: Cornelius.

And seated beside them, in an overcoat, a familiar face: President Joe Biden (81), here because he promised.

INT. ABC NEWS — SPECIAL COVERAGE — NIGHT

SUPER: 7:49 PM EDT

DAVID MUIR
Let's go live to Philadelphia, where an enormous crowd has gathered on the Benjamin Franklin Parkway for what the Bullock campaign is calling its closing argument. President Biden is there, as is Bullock's family, including his ninety-six-year-old grandmother-in-law, Odessa Smilley, who famously cast Georgia's votes at the convention.

EXT. PHILADELPHIA MUSEUM OF ART — THE STEPS — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 7:52 PM EDT

The President briefly introduces the nominee: a few warm minutes, a joke about how the young man "ran up these steps faster than I ever could," and a line about how he once was too young too. Then Marc

comes out, not from behind the podium, but running up the seventy-two steps from the bottom, through the crowd, two at a time. When he hits the top, he turns and throws both arms in the air, exactly like the movie.

The parkway erupts. A hundred and ten thousand people. The band plays the theme from that movie, because of course it does.

Marc, out of breath, laughing, grabs the microphone.

MARC
I've wanted to do that since I was seven years old.

ROAR.

MARC
Philadelphia. One week.

(beat)
Five hundred and fifty-three days ago, a nine-year-old girl at her birthday party asked me why I couldn't fix it. She's ten now. She's right there.

A camera finds Lyric. She waves. The crowd screams her name.

MARC
I didn't have an answer that day. I've spent five hundred and fifty-three days looking for it. I went to Detroit and ate hot dogs at two Coney Islands. I sat in Jim Clyburn's church and listened for two hours. I stood in a Black church in Atlanta and watched my father-in-law turn his palm up to my wife. I handed out water in the mud in Swannanoa next to that same father-in-law. I stood on a dock in San Juan yesterday and told three million Americans they're not garbage.

(beat)
And here's what I found out. The answer isn't me. It was never me. It's you.

(beat)
I'm not going to stand up here and tell you Donald Trump is evil. He isn't. He's a man who's been shot at twice this year and kept going. He's my opponent, not my enemy. I'm going to stand up here and tell you he's wrong. About the future. About

who we are. About what this country can still do.

A rolling applause.

MARC
They say I'm too young. In seven days, a lot of you are going to vote for the first time. Eighteen. Nineteen. Twenty. You know what you are? Too young. Everybody's told you that your whole life. Too young to understand. Too young to matter. Too young to change anything.

(beat)
Prove 'em wrong.

A noise from the younger end of the crowd like a stadium after a game-winning touchdown.

MARC
And to everybody who's old enough to remember when this country built things. When a factory job could buy a house. When your kids did better than you. I remember too, because my great-great-grandfather couldn't buy a house in Burbank in his own name, and his great-great-grandson is standing on these steps. That's what this country can do. That's what it's supposed to do. I'm not asking you to trust me because I'm young. I'm asking you to trust me because I'm stubborn.

(laughter)
I was told I couldn't run. I ran. I was told I couldn't win a primary. I won. I was told Congress would never pass an amendment. They passed it. I was told Texas was impossible.

A camera finds a hand-drawn sign: "TEXAS +2 — DON'T MAKE IT A WHOLE THING."

MARC
Two points, y'all.

The crowd LOSES IT.

MARC
One more thing. I need you to vote for me. And I need you to vote for every Democrat for the House of Representatives on your ballot. Not because they're Democrats. Because if thirty-three states becomes thirty-eight, I take the oath on January twentieth. And if it doesn't, the House picks the President. So when you vote for me, vote for the House too. Think of it as insurance.

(beat)
And then call your state legislators. All of you. In Kentucky, in Missouri, in Montana. Tell them a little girl asked a question, and they get to answer it.

He looks out at the parkway. At the city. At Esther, on the steps behind him. At Odessa in her wheelchair, and Cornelius standing behind her.

MARC
Seven days. Bring your mama. Bring your grandma. Bring your Republican uncle. Especially your Republican uncle.

(beat)
They say it's impossible.

He holds out the mic.

CROWD
(a hundred and ten thousand people)
BET!

Fireworks over the Schuylkill River. The theme from that movie again. Marc turns and goes straight to Odessa, kneels down in front of her wheelchair, and kisses her hand. Odessa pats his cheek. Behind her, Cornelius, his hand still on his mother's shoulder, looks down at his son-in-law kneeling. And nods once.

SUPER: 8:31 PM EDT — CLOSING ARGUMENT — AN ESTIMATED 110,000 ON THE PARKWAY, 41 MILLION WATCHING ACROSS PLATFORMS

ACT FOUR — "THE RACE"

INT. ABC NEWS — SPECIAL COVERAGE — NIGHT

SUPER: 9:04 PM EDT

Muir, George Stephanopoulos (63), the Political Director, Dr. Malcolm Reese (55), Rep. (Ret.) Diane Kastle (61).

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
One hundred and ten thousand people on the Parkway. That's one of the largest political rallies in Philadelphia history.

DAVID MUIR
Congresswoman Kastle. Does Trump have a path?

REP. (RET.) DIANE KASTLE
Absolutely. Don't let a crowd fool you, David. Crowds don't vote. People do. And Trump's voters don't show up at rallies on the Parkway, they show up on Election Day. He's within one in Arizona. He's tied in North Carolina. If he flips Pennsylvania, and he's down three there, inside the margin, the whole thing flips. And his border message is the most effective single issue in this race. Immigration is the one issue where more voters trust Trump than Bullock, by nine points.

DR. MALCOLM REESE
But David, look at the coalition. Bullock is winning young voters by thirty points. Black voters by numbers that look like Obama in 2008, after he struggled with older Black voters in the primary. Latino voters, especially after the Madison Square Garden remark, by twenty points or more. And he's at seventeen percent among Republicans. That's a number no Democrat has touched in modern history.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
Seventeen percent of Republicans.

DR. MALCOLM REESE
Roy Chapman, George. Roy Chapman is a demographic now.

DAVID MUIR
And the wildcard? The thirty-eight states?

ABC POLITICAL DIRECTOR
That's the thing no forecast can model. Even if Bullock wins on November fifth, there's a second election happening, in state legislatures, over the next eleven weeks. And a third election, in the House, that decides the backup plan. We have never had a presidential election with this many layers.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
The Kid Mayor's final exam.

DAVID MUIR
Seven days.

MONTAGE — THE INTERNET — OCTOBER 29–30, 2024

Twitter · #ClosingArgument

Trending #1 Worldwide · 4.4M Tweets

Twitter · #DontMakeItAWholeThing

Trending #2 in United States · 2.1M Tweets

Twitter · @TheBullpenDaily

HE RAN UP THE ROCKY STEPS. HE KISSED ODESSA'S HAND. CORNELIUS NODDED. JOE BIDEN WAS THERE. 110,000 PEOPLE. "PROVE 'EM WRONG." SEVEN DAYS. I NEED A NAP AND I NEED TO VOTE AND I CAN ONLY DO ONE AT A TIME.

402K Retweets · 2.9M Likes

Twitter · @PattiGrove

I specifically said no running up the steps. He specifically ran up the steps. 41 million people watched him run up the steps. I'm adding "running up the steps" to the list of things I told him not to do that worked.

141K Retweets · 1.1M Likes

Twitter · @PhillyPD

Estimated crowd on the Parkway tonight: approximately 110,000. No major incidents. Thank you, Philadelphia.

22K Retweets · 140K Likes

TikTok · @first.time.voter.ella

[Video: an 18-year-old in a Temple hoodie, crying, as Marc says "Prove 'em wrong"] "i turned 18 three weeks ago and everybody keeps telling me i'm too young to understand politics. i'm voting next tuesday. watch me."

22.1M views · 6.4M likes

Twitter · @AZborderdad

I'm in Yuma. I'm a Bullock voter. But I'm telling the campaign right now: "every immigrant is legal" scares people here. Say "orderly." Say "secure." You're losing Arizona on one word.

31K Retweets · 188K Likes

Twitter · @AZborderdad's replies

@BullockForAmerica: "We hear you. Orderly. Secure. Legal. Every word."

61K Likes

Twitter · @jaxonwilde

Bullock had Biden on stage and a 96-year-old in a wheelchair as props. Wilde Card is the only show telling the truth.

3,108 Retweets · 9K Likes

Twitter · @TayiaBoyd

@jaxonwilde Jaxon, that "96-year-old prop" cast Georgia's votes at the convention and raised three children and buried a husband and a son and has sat in the same pew since 1952. You spoke at a rally where they called Puerto Rico garbage. Sit down.

412K Retweets · 3.1M Likes

Twitter · @SimoneSmilley

For the record, my grandmother was not a prop. She was the reason. She told me to say that.

201K Retweets · 1.7M Likes

Twitter · @ConstitutionCarl

33 states. Not 38. If Bullock wins next week, January 20th could be the first constitutional crisis in a peaceful transfer of power in American history. Vote accordingly.

18K Retweets · 81K Likes

Twitter · @ConstitutionCarl's replies

@ArizonaGrandpa: "Carl, after 18 months, I finally agree with you on something: vote accordingly. I already did. You'll never guess for who."

101K Likes

Reddit · r/politics

"Bullock closes on Philly's Art Museum steps before ~110K; Biden, Odessa and Cornelius Smilley join; 538 has Bullock at 74%; 33 of 38 states have ratified"

302K upvotes · 61,882 comments · Top comment: "The father-in-law arc on this campaign is better than any prestige TV show I've ever watched. He went from 'that Donohue' to handing out water in the mud to standing behind his mom's wheelchair on the Rocky steps."

Reddit · r/fivethirtyeight

"74/26 is NOT a lock. Please, for the love of God, everybody remember 2016."

88K upvotes · Top comment: "I'm voting like it's 50/50 and so should you."

ASSOCIATED PRESS

Bullock delivers closing argument on Philadelphia Art Museum steps before massive crowd, urges voters to back House Democrats as 'insurance'

THE NEW YORK TIMES

One Week Out, Bullock Leads in Polls but the Race, and the Constitution, Remain Unsettled

THE WASHINGTON POST

The 2024 election comes down to seven states, a few House seats, and five state legislatures

THE PHILADELPHIA INQUIRER

110,000 on the Parkway: Bullock Runs Up the Rocky Steps, and Philadelphia Runs With Him

POLITICO PLAYBOOK — WED, OCT 30

The race in one number: 17 (the percentage of Republicans backing Bullock)

AXIOS

Seven days out: The Bullock-Trump race by the numbers

FIVETHIRTYEIGHT

Final week forecast: Bullock is favored, but a Trump win is well within the range of outcomes

FOX NEWS

Trump Closes Strong in Arizona, North Carolina; Border Remains Top Issue as Bullock Rallies in Philly

THE TEXAS TRIBUNE

Texas Within Two Points: Inside the Roy Chapman Effect

THE ATLANTA JOURNAL-CONSTITUTION

Cornelius Smilley, Once Biden's Firewall, Now Barnstorming Carolina Churches for His Son-in-Law

EL NUEVO DÍA

Puerto Rican Voters in Pennsylvania and Florida Could Decide the Election, Analysts Say

VARIETY

From Kid Mayor to the Rocky Steps: Inside Robert Bullock's Visual Strategy for His Son's Campaign

THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER

Hollywood's Election Week: Every Studio Has a Watch Party, and Every Publicist Has a Prediction

DEADLINE

Tyrese Avery, Unseen Since His DNC Performance, Expected to Skip Election Night; 'Sabbatical' Continues

TAG

INT. RITZ-CARLTON PHILADELPHIA — PRESIDENTIAL SUITE — NIGHT

SUPER: WEDNESDAY, OCTOBER 30, 2024 — 12:44 AM EDT

A hotel suite in a former bank, with a rotunda ceiling. The kids are asleep in the adjoining room. Esther has gone to bed. Marc, still in his rally clothes, tie loose, sits alone at a dining table with a cold plate of cheesesteak and his phone.

A knock. Dante opens the door. Behind him, alone, in an overcoat: Cornelius (66). Under his arm, a thick, worn three-ring binder.

DANTE
Sir. Mr. Smilley.

MARC
(standing)
Dad. It's almost one.

CORNELIUS
I know what time it is. I'm sixty-six, not senile.

He walks in. Dante closes the door and stays outside. Cornelius sets the binder on the dining table between them. The white spine label, in his precise handwriting:

"THE BULLOCK FILE."

Marc looks at it for a long time. He has known it existed for eighteen months. He has never seen it.

MARC
...So that's what it looks like.

CORNELIUS
That's what it looks like.

MARC
It's thinner than I thought.

CORNELIUS
I shredded the part about my granddaughters on Memorial Day. And I gave one section to a man named Wes Thornton in September of last year. The comedy. You know which ads I mean.

Marc nods slowly.

MARC
I figured.

CORNELIUS
Your security man figured too. He has a photograph of me at the Hay-Adams. He's had it since April of last year. Your campaign never used it. Not in the primary. Not after I joined Biden. Not once.

MARC
Elxa said if we leaked it, the story would be "Bullock attacks wife's family."

CORNELIUS
Elxa's right. But you could have used it. In South Carolina. In Georgia. Any campaign in America would have.

MARC
I'm not any campaign.

CORNELIUS
No.

(beat)
You're not.

He slides the binder across the table.

CORNELIUS
Everything else is in there. Every rule you broke. Every customs form from the PPE flights. Every FDA letter about the formula. The lunch-debt lawsuit. The charter flights. Every joke you told on HBO in 2015, transcribed, timestamped, sorted by which voters it would offend most.

(beat)
It's yours.

MARC
Why?

CORNELIUS
Because in seven days you might be President-elect of the United States. And every enemy you'll ever have is going to build one of these. Republicans. Foreign governments. Reporters. Your own party, someday. They'll all have a copy, and it'll look a lot like this one.

(beat)
I spent ten years building the best one in existence. You should know what's in it before they do.

Marc puts his hand on the binder. Doesn't open it.

MARC
Dad. Can I ask you something?

CORNELIUS
You can ask.

MARC
When did you stop?

A long silence. Cornelius walks to the window. The Philadelphia skyline. City Hall with William Penn on top.

CORNELIUS
I didn't stop all at once. Nobody does. I stopped a little in Esther's call last April, when she said Thaddeus's name. A little more when the girls sent me that first cake. A little more when Joe Biden told me nobody wins a fight against their own kid. When you said "See you in Georgia" on national television after I'd just beaten you in North Carolina. When my mother cast Georgia's votes and I heard myself say my own name.

(beat)
And the rest of the way in a church parking lot in Swannanoa, when an old woman in a nightgown asked me if I was voting for you, and I heard myself say yes before I'd decided.

(beat)
I'd decided a long time before that. I just hadn't told myself.

Marc gets up. Walks to the window. Stands next to his father-in-law. Two men looking out at a city that has seen a lot of history.

MARC
Thaddeus. Esther told me some of it. Not all of it.

CORNELIUS
Someday I'll tell you all of it. After the election. When we have time.

(beat)
He would have liked you. That's the hell of it. He'd have liked you so much. He was funny. He used to stand on furniture.

Marc turns to look at him.

MARC
...He stood on furniture?

CORNELIUS
My mother's couch. Every Christmas. Making speeches. Pretending to be the President. My father would yell at him to get down, and he'd say, "Daddy, when I'm President, I'll stand wherever I want."

A long silence. Marc's eyes are wet.

CORNELIUS
Go to bed, son. Seven days.

He turns to leave. At the door, he stops. Doesn't turn around.

CORNELIUS
And Marc.

MARC
Yeah?

CORNELIUS
Win Pennsylvania.

The door closes behind him.

Marc stands alone in the rotunda suite. Then he walks back to the table, sits down, and finally opens "THE BULLOCK FILE." First tab. "2012 — PREGNANCY." Empty. Shredded. He turns to the next. And the next. And on the last page, the very last one, in the back pocket of the binder, a single photograph he's never seen before: a young man in a late-sixties suit, laughing on the steps of the Georgia State Capitol, one arm around a beautiful young woman in a Spelman sweater.

On the back, in faded ink: "Thad & Joan — Spring '69."

And beneath it, in fresh ink, Cornelius's handwriting:

"He'd have stood on the couch for you. — C."

SMASH TO BLACK.

SUPER: ELECTION DAY: TUESDAY, NOVEMBER 5, 2024 — 6 DAYS

SUPER: END OF CHAPTER NINE

CONTINUITY LEDGER — CHAPTER 9

Timeline: Mon Aug 19, 2024 (DNC Night 1) → montage → **Tue Oct 29, 2024 (one week before Election Day): "World News Tonight" 6:30 PM EDT; closing argument at the Philadelphia Museum of Art steps 7:52–8:31 PM EDT** → Wed Oct 30, 12:44 AM EDT (tag). Daylight Saving Time ends Sun Nov 3, 2024. Election Day: Tue Nov 5, 2024.

Ages (Oct 29, 2024): Marc 32 · **Esther 32 (turned 32 Sep 20, in Kenosha)** · Amond 32 · Harmony 32 · Emma & Victoria 12 · Lyric 10 · Tyrese 33 · **Arianna 32 (Oct 25, in Frankfort, KY)** · Tyler 32 · Tayia 32 · **Elxa 34 (Aug 29, at a Sheetz in Erie, PA)** · Grace 30 · Natasha 53 · Robert 55 · Victor 78 · Joan 76 · **Odessa 96 (Oct 3)** · Cornelius 66 · Lorraine 62 · Neil 40 · Simone 37 · Patti 60 · Dante 43 · Wes Thornton 45 · Roy Chapman 67 · Mae Chapman 65 (fictional, Roy's wife) · Gloria Baker 58. At the DNC (Aug 19–22): Odessa 95, Cornelius 66, Esther 31, Elxa 33. Real people: Trump 78 · Vance 40 · Biden 81 · Muir 50 · Stephanopoulos 63 · Speaker Johnson 52.

Real events depicted: DNC in Chicago (United Center, Aug 19–22); RFK Jr. suspends and endorses Trump (Aug 23); second assassination attempt at Trump's West Palm Beach golf course (Sep 15); Fed cuts 0.5 points (Sep 18); Hurricane Helene in western NC (Swannanoa, Chimney Rock, Asheville), Sep 26–29; Vance in the VP debate on CBS in NYC (Oct 1); Hurricane Milton (Oct 9, Siesta Key); September CPI 2.4% (Oct 10); Trump's Madison Square Garden rally (Sun Oct 27), with a comedian's "floating island of garbage" remark about Puerto Rico; about 53M early votes by Oct 29; the Senate landscape (Tester–Sheehy, Brown–Moreno, Casey–McCormick, Allred–Cruz, Justice in WV, Manchin retiring); the last Democrat to win Texas was Carter in 1976.

Our-world events: DNC "Culture's Biggest Night": Robert as creative director; a live band; Night 1 hosts Tayia and Tyler; Biden's valedictory ("Kid, you've got this"); the in memoriam. **Night 2 roll call:** Cornelius yields to Odessa: "Georgia casts 108 votes for the next President... My grandson-in-law," then "...so does Cornelius Smilley," with "Georgia on My Mind." Night 3: Amond's acceptance (Gloria introduces him). **Night 4: Tyrese performs "Afterglow" and returns to the "sabbatical" (Kang still secret).** Natasha in Section 324, Row 11 ($340, her own card). Marc reads Cornelius's envelope backstage. Acceptance line: "one country, 335 million people, zero people left behind." Cornelius hugs Marc onstage. DNC final night: 38M viewers. **One presidential debate: Tue Sep 10, NBC, National Constitution Center, Philadelphia** (ABC ruled out over the Donohue conflict); Trump strong early; Marc praises Trump's courage; CNN instant poll Bullock 58–39. Marc calls Trump after the Sep 15 attempt. **Sep 29, Swannanoa:** Marc and Cornelius hand out water, no press; Cornelius: "Yes, ma'am. I am [voting for him]." Roy Chapman

calls Cornelius on Thursdays. **VP debate Oct 1:** Vance 49, Baker 47, a near-draw. Oct 3: Odessa's 96th with a church-hat cake. **Oct 14: the Roy Chapman ad ("Don't make it a whole thing")**, 140M views in 48 hours. Jaxon Wilde speaks at the MSG rally (Oct 27). **Oct 28: Marc in San Juan at La Perla** (site of the 2017 Maria flotilla): "You're not garbage. You're Americans." **Oct 28: Simone announces she'll vote for Bullock on CNN** ("I'm going with character"; Odessa: "Took you long enough"). Polls Oct 29: national Bullock 51.2, Trump 45.4 (post-DNC peak +11); 538 forecast Bullock 74/100; safe/likely EVs Bullock 226, Trump 219; MI +5, WI +4, PA +3, GA +2, NC tied, NV +4, AZ Trump +1, TX Trump +2, FL Trump +4; Bullock at 17% of Republicans; immigration is the one issue where Trump leads (+9). House: generic ballot D+5, Democrats favored 68/100. Senate: Tester tied, Brown +1, Casey +2, Allred within 1. **28th Amendment: 33 of 38 states ratified**; 9 realistic remaining; 4 governors promise special sessions after the election. Arianna in Frankfort 3×; the Montana legislative counsel's dog is Gunner (a Labrador). Wes Thornton: Trump paid-media strategist, "He Wants to Erase It" ads, the folder "BULLOCK — ROAST MATERIAL (SOURCE: CS)." Roy's father voted for LBJ in 1964 (secret kept by Roy's mother). Closing argument: ~110,000 on the Parkway, Marc runs up the 72 steps, Biden introduces him, "Prove 'em wrong," "vote for the House as insurance," 41M watching. **Tag: Cornelius gives Marc THE BULLOCK FILE** (the 2012 tab shredded; the roast tab went to Wes), with the Thad & Joan photo in the back pocket ("He'd have stood on the couch for you. — C."). Thaddeus stood on Odessa's couch every Christmas pretending to be President. Cornelius: "Win Pennsylvania."

Fictional people introduced: Mae Chapman (65).

Looming event (in-world): ELECTION DAY, Tue Nov 5, 2024 (6 days). Plus 28th Amendment ratification (33/38).